

The POW issue

As a counter to the peace movement and to acquire political support for the administration, Nixon and his aides began to prioritize the demand for the release of American prisoners of war. The tactic produced mixed results. Many Americans had been willing to fight communism, but they had become opposed to the continuation of a costly war to maintain the unpopular Saigon regime. By making POW release an issue, Nixon gained backing from POW families and from pro-war individuals, notably millionaire H. Ross Perot, who headed the United We Stand organization, which lobbied to continue the war primarily for the purpose of POW release. Backed by the administration, some members of Congress, and the media, the National League of Families of American Prisoners and Missing in Southeast Asia was formed in May 1970.

While successful in gaining support at home, diplomatically the focus on POWs backfired. The North Vietnamese reasoned that their negotiators could use offers to release POWs as leverage to gain the concessions it wanted from the United States to reduce its support for the Thieu government.

The longest-held American civilian prisoner was Ernest Brace, a contract pilot taken in Laos in May 1965 and held for nearly seven years.



Zoo inspection

American POWs stand for an inspection by international observers in the yard at Hanoi's Nga Tu So prison, nicknamed the Zoo, on March 29, 1973, just before their release. They left the prison shortly after, still dressed in their prison uniforms.